Business Reader : Voice AI

Session 7 · 5 October 2026 · 90 minutes

Reading: "The unit economics of India's voice AI boom"

BUSINESS READER

Session Outcomes

1. Reading Framework

3 passes on an analysis article; spot the missing unit

2. Business Accumen

Price per minute, cost per minute, gross margin, volume

3. Article Analysis & Data Restructuring

Minto pyramid; turn sentences into one per-minute P&L

4. POV Formulation

Per minute or per outcome: which pricing wins?

PART 1 · BEFORE THE ARTICLE

What a voice AI agent actually does

One EMI-reminder call, in four steps. It runs on a phone line, and every step is a bill.

1 · EAR

Listens

Turns the customer's speech into text, even Hinglish on a noisy street

→

2 · BRAIN

Thinks

An AI model decides the reply, within the bank's script and rules

→

3 · MOUTH

Speaks

Turns the reply back into a natural voice, in under a second

→

4 · HANDS

Acts

Logs the promise to pay, updates the bank's system, passes hard cases to a human

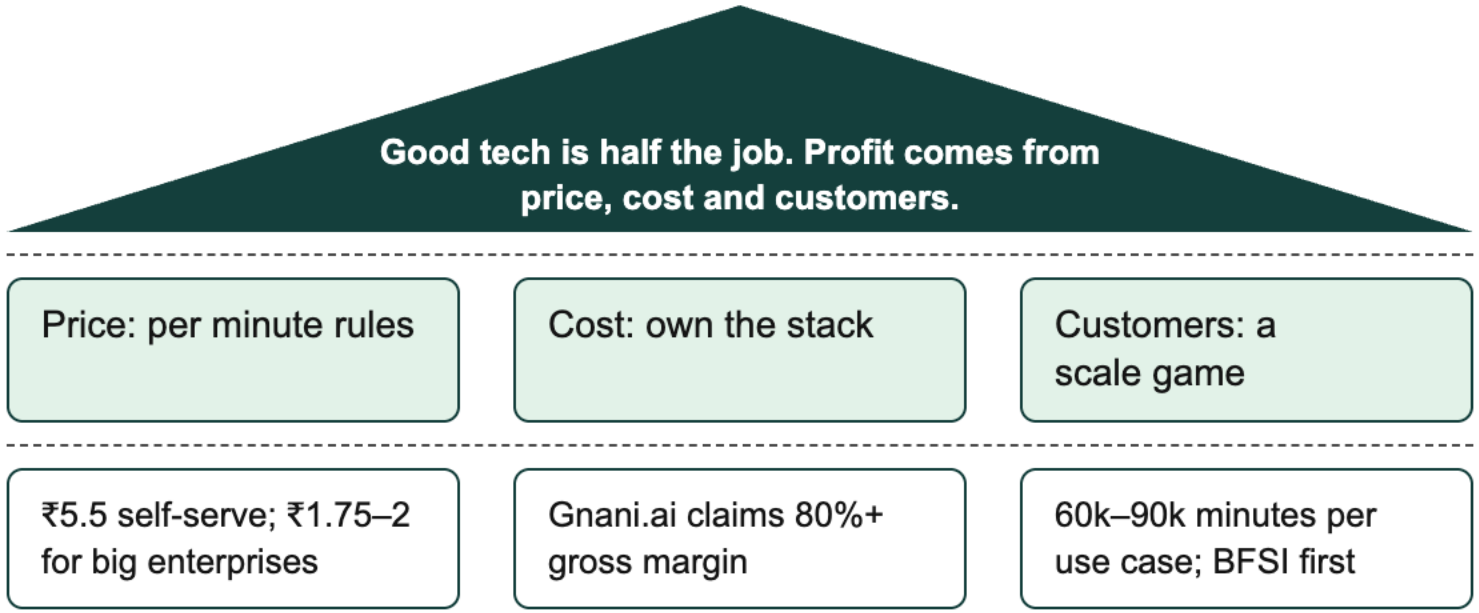
Question. Each step needs software and computers. What if a startup rents every step from someone else?

THE ANSWER

Every step is a cost line: phone line, listening, thinking, speaking. It's a trade-off between speed of execution (where you can rent intelligence from other companies) and margins (where you optimize and build it internally).

PART 2 · STEP 1 : 3 PASSES

The article's pyramid



Question. Which piece of evidence would you check first, and why?

THE ANSWER

The 80% margin. Prices and customers are visible in the market, but the margin is one company's own claim, and the whole "own the stack" pillar rests on it.

CARD 1A · PRICE

The pricing sentence

"Self-serve customers typically pay around ₹5.5 per minute, while enterprises committing to significantly larger, long-term volumes can negotiate rates as low as ₹1.75-₹2 per minute."

Who handles the call	Price per minute	Saving vs human	Saving %
Human call centre	₹7–8	Base	Base
Voice AI, self-serve buyer	₹5.5	₹1.5–2.5	About 25%
Voice AI, big enterprise	₹1.75–2	₹5–6	About 75%

Question. The biggest customers pay about a third of the price. Why would a startup agree to that?

THE ANSWER

Volume cuts the startup's own cost too: cheaper infrastructure deals, reuse of common answers, lighter models. Like a wholesaler, it earns less per unit but far more in total.

Source: the article. Human cost excludes hiring, training and attrition. Savings calculated.

CARD 1B · COST

The margin sentence

"Gnani.ai has built most of these capabilities in-house... The company claims this enables gross margins exceeding 80%."

Per minute, enterprise deal	Owner (Gnani's claim)	Renter (illustrative)
Price	₹2.00	₹2.00
Cost of the call	₹0.40 or less	₹1.50 (assumed)
Gross profit	₹1.60	₹0.50
Gross margin	80%+	25%

Question. Same price, same customer. Now the customer asks for 20% off. What happens to each?

THE ANSWER

At ₹1.60, the owner still keeps ₹1.20 (75%). The renter keeps 10 paise (about 6%). Owning the stack is what lets you survive price cuts, and competition keeps pushing prices down.

Source: the article. Owner cost derived from the 80% claim; renter cost is an illustrative assumption.

CARD 1C · CUSTOMERS

The buyer sentence

"Customer acquisition, cross-selling and collections often receive budget approval faster than customer support because enterprises can directly measure their business impact."

	Volume Low	Volume High
High Ability to Attribute	**WORKS, BUT SMALL** B2B meeting booking Home-loan lead follow-up Car test-drive booking	**STARTS HERE** EMI collections Loan and card cross-sell Cash-on-delivery order confirmation Insurance renewals; hiring screens
Low Ability to Attribute	**STAYS HUMAN** Private banking Wealth advice Complaint escalations	**COST PLAY ONLY** Order-status and FAQ support Feedback calls Government scheme outreach

Source: the article. Use-case placement is a point of view for discussion.

TAKEAWAY 1 OF 2

In voice AI, margin is a design choice: use the expensive brain only on the minutes that need it.

The price is capped by the human it replaces. The phone line, ear and mouth keep getting cheaper; the smartest reasoning models do not. Winners send each call to the cheapest model that can handle it.

PART 3 · POV FORMULATION

Should a voice AI startup charge per minute, or per loan recovered?

THE ANSWER

Today, per minute: whether a loan is repaid depends on many things the bot cannot control. Tomorrow, a mix: a base fee per minute plus a bonus per loan recovered.

3.1 · PRICING MODELS

Three ways to charge, side by side

Model	Who carries the risk	Works best when
Per minute	The buyer: pays even if nothing is recovered	Volumes are steady; results depend on many outside factors
Per outcome	The startup: earns only if the loan is repaid	The result is clear, countable and mostly in the bot's control
Hybrid	Shared: base fee plus bonus	Most large deployments; founders expect this to win

Question. Per-minute prices keep falling (Card 1A). Which model protects a startup from that?

THE ANSWER

Outcome-linked pricing. Competition keeps pushing the price of a minute down; the value of a recovered loan does not fall. Selling results escapes the price war. Hybrid is the bridge.

Source: the article. Table is our restructuring of its argument.

TAKEAWAY 2 OF 2

Sell the outcome, not the minute.

Competition sets the price of a minute. The value of a recovered loan is set by the loan. Pricing on outcomes takes you out of the race to the bottom, but only where the outcome can be counted.

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What will you check in the next voice AI article?

1. Price	Per minute, and who pays it: self-serve or big enterprise
2. Cost	Which steps the company owns, and which it rents
3. Margin	The number, and who claims it
4. Volume	Minutes per what: per month, per year, per client?
5. Pricing model	Per minute, per outcome, or a mix

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Session Outcomes

1. Reading Framework

3 passes; "the company claims"; always ask "per what?"

2. Business Accumen

Price, cost and gross margin per minute; volume threshold

3. Article Analysis & Data Restructuring

Pyramid, owner vs renter P&L, buyer table

4. POV Formulation

Sell the outcome, not the minute; 5-point checklist